

DIDI HITS A HIGH NOTE

Trust West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee** to keep the meme economy booming. On May 26, during a solemn tribute to rebel poet Kazi Nazrul Islam, cabinet colleague Indranil Sen was singing a usual Nazrul song. But Didi, never one to let a wrong note slide, abruptly stopped him mid-performance. "You're off tune," she declared and belted out "*Nayana bhara jal go tomar*" herself. Soon, the duo was doing an impromptu duet. The internet, of course, exploded. Sure, music experts might wince at her pitch, but Didi's confidence? Unshakeable.

Ajit, Power-that-be Not

After being dropped from the Devendra Fadnavis-led cabinet in Maharashtra last year, NCP veteran and OBC leader **Chhagan Bhujbal** had made no bones about his frustration and anger. But with the local polls looming, the man is back as minister. What has got political circles buzzing, though, is that Bhujbal has chosen to thank the BJP leadership rather than his party chief and deputy CM Ajit Pawar for his rehabilitation.





JUICY CARGO

As summer ripens across the Indian subcontinent, Air India has, in one of its first forays, assumed a juicy mission: ferrying nearly 1,000 tonnes of mangoes to markets in North America, Europe, West Asia and other global destinations. From Alphonsos to Dussehris, the fruit gets transported cold-chain-style from Indian orchards to global shelves, packed in certified facilities. With loads going to 43 destinations in 31 countries, mangoes have turned into one of Air India's most adored cargo categories, a testament to India's summer obsession going global, one heady box at a time.

Kaushik Deka with Pradip R. Sagar, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Rohit Parihar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Avishek G. Dastidar

ECO WATCH

By **Jumana Shah** *&* **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

A 45,000-ACRE LOSS OF FOREST



The woods may be dark and deep, but India is losing it at an alarming rate. In 2024, the country lost 18,200 hectares (about 45,000 acres) of primary forest cover, a jump of 2.8 percentage point from 2023. The data, released recently by the World Research Institute's Global Forest Watch platform, says the country also lost 126,000 ha. of tree cover. From 2002 to 2024, India has lost 348,000 ha. of humid primary forest, making up 15 per cent of its total tree cover. The primary driver (60.9 per cent) is 'shifting agriculture', or slash-and-burn farming where forests are cleared for a short while for cultivation and then abandoned; followed by 27.2 per cent lost to permanent agriculture.

AIR POLLUTION KOLKATA BREATHES EASY



The City gets some Joy back, having earned the third-highest performance-based incentive of Rs 184.5 crore from the Union ministry of environment, forest and climate change for reducing air pollution. Kolkata was in the top 10 most polluted cities list in 2019, with the city recording average PM10 levels of 100µg per cubic metre and AQI of 343 at Fort William—categorised as 'very poor'. As of May 2025, PM10 levels had dropped to 47–50µg per cu.m., with AQI improving to a healthy 73. A multi-pronged strategy of stricter solid waste management, widespread use of water sprinklers and mist cannons, enforcing scaffolding nets at construction sites, phasing out old vehicles et al helped. Kolkata also committed to planting 10 million saplings.